Palestinians meant pouring more fuel on a well-known fire. The Hamas leaders may have calculated that the policies that divided Israeli society and strengthened pro-Palestinian opinion worldwide were the right moment for their attack; they didn't foresee that the atrocities of their "fighters" would shift part of world opinion back in favor of Israel and, most importantly, would unite Israeli society in defense of the country.

According to both Israeli and American estimates, 162 Israelis have been taken hostage. Half of them are believed to be dead.

Smotrich will have to change course or go. It is clear—and an excellent article published today on *Ynet* was merely a warning— that the minister of finance will have to drastically revise his priorities and shift billions to postwar reconstruction of the communities in the South that were destroyed by the October 7 aggression and to psychological, medical, and professional help for the survivors of that trauma. From where will these huge sums be drawn at first, if not from the enormous budgets allocated over the last few months to the religious parties and to the settlements in the Occupied Territories? The end of the coalition bonanza.

Settlers attacked a funeral procession in the West Bank and killed a father and his son, according to Palestinian reports. This is the second incident of this type since the beginning of the war. Otherwise, there is only waiting regarding Gaza, regarding the northern border, and regarding the West Bank and Jerusalem. Tense waiting. No sign yet of any move regarding the hostages and the prisoners.

Friday, October 13

Israel ordered more than 1 million Palestinians living in the northern part of the Gaza enclave to evacuate their homes within twenty-four hours, probably in preparation for the army's occupation. One can only hope that